

Phaser 3117, which scored somewhat lower than the others, the differences amongst the rest are negligible.

Speed

We clocked the printers for warm-up times and print speeds. The Xerox Phaser 3117 was the fastest in the speed tests, but that alone wasn't sufficient to make it the winner. The Brother HL-5170DN performed remarkably better than the Brother HL-6050DN when printing our 36.9 MB PDF file.

The Verdict

The Price as a factor also plays a role in the final tally, especially the price of the toner/cartridge. The Brother HL-5170DN scored only reasonably well in performance, but it raced ahead in the features departments. It is priced at Rs 21,900, and the toner is Rs 4,315. The Samsung ML-2010 is affordable at Rs 9,990 but it isn't as feature-rich as the Brother HL-5170DN.

The HL-5170DN from Brother is the Digit Best Buy Gold winner, and the Samsung ML-2010 gets the Digit Best Buy Silver.

We should make a special mention here of the Canon LBP2900 for the output clarity it delivered. At Rs 8,995, it is the most affordable printer amongst all the ones we tested.

COLOUR LASER PRINTERS Features

In the tests we conducted last year and the year before, we also received printers with 300 x 300 dpi resolution. This year has seen a change in this figure: all three printers in this segment have a minimum resolution of 600 x 600 dpi—a step above 300 x 300.

Network Support

The Epson AL-C1100 and Brother HL-2700 CN are higher up in the features segment as their printers are network-ready; Canon LBP5200 preferred to provide Ethernet as an optional interface. We think they should reconsider this, since network support is important for offices—printers as large as colour lasers are much more likely to be shared over a network than to be used as desktop printers.

Physical Considerations

All three printers are very heavy. The lightest is Canon's LBP5200, at slightly over 15 kg. Since the printers are huge, we considered the dimensions in our comparison, taking the footprint (base area) into account. Canon's LBP5200 is unusually large, particularly because its tray capacity is 125 (A4) sheets, and because of its different toner/cartridge arrangement.

Displays And Memory

Only the Brother and the Epson have an LCD display. Moreover, the Canon LBP5200 has a meagre 8 MB of installed memory, and they actually justified it by stating Hi-SCoA—a compression technology. Brother HL-2700 CN and the Epson AL-C1100 have 32 MB of installed memory, upgradeable to 576 MB and 256 MB respectively. In addition to this, the Brother has a Compact Flash memory card reader slot.

The usefulness of a memory card reader varies; for example, those using the printers on a network would have little need for one, whereas a photographer might. But in general, this feature is not a real value-add, since

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Epson AL-C1100

The perfect machine for a small office setup

If your specifications are simple—that is, if you need a mono laser printer that produces good printouts while being cost effective—your search ends here. Brother's HL-6050 DN is a network-ready printer for your office that has an input tray capacity of 500 sheets (A4). The printer measures 40 x 42.5 x 31 cm, and weighs 20 kg. The drawer-based paper tray has a nifty arrangement to display the paper level in the tray: we liked this idea, since there's no way you can otherwise deduce the paper level once the tray is shut. An LCD panel with a sufficient number of buttons enables proper interaction with the printer; note that very few mono laser printers incorporate an LCD display. There's also support for Linux in addition to Mac and Windows.

The installed 32 MB of memory can be upgraded to up to 160 MB. Speaking of memory, Brother's HL-6050 DN was the only printer in the mono laser segment to feature a Compact Flash (CF) memory card reader. The printer supports three resolution modes—300 x 300, 600 x 600 and 1200 x 1200 dpi. For text-only printing, the 300 dpi setting is sufficient, and for documents that involve graphs and patterns,

600 dpi is ideal—1200 dpi for a mono laser is not something you'd often need to use.

To test the printer on the performance front, we printed various types of documents, from text to graphs, and also clocked the printer for these jobs. The HL 6050 DN did not disappoint us as far as the quality of printouts was concerned, but it did take too long to print our large (36.9 MB) PDF file—a little over four minutes. Windows XP's printer task dialog box showed the file being transferred at a very low 5 kbps. The delay could have been due to a bug in the printer driver, since the printer itself supports the high-speed USB 2.0 interface, and so does our test machine. Apart from this, the printer's response was spot on!

The Brother HL 6050 DN delivered better clarity than most in our sample business document test. The document featured graphs, logos, textures and pictures in addition to text. Other test printouts were very clear as well.



Cost of printer: **Rs 27,750**
Cost of toner: **Rs 4,980**
Rating: **4/5**